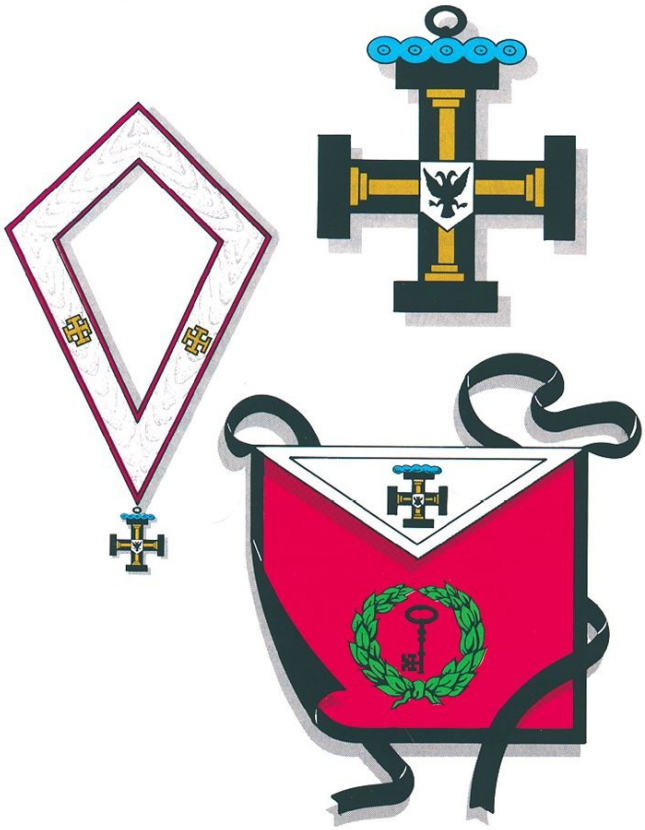
The 28th Degree – Knight Commander of the Temple



In the *Liturgy* Pike describes the apron thus: “The APRON is square, of scarlet–colored lambskin, lined and edged with black. The flap is white, and on it is a Teutonic Cross described as a cross potent sable, charged with another cross double potent or, surcharged with an escutcheon of the Empire, the principal Cross surmounted by a chief azure, seme of France;....” He is using the technical terminology of heraldry: “potent” is a word used to describe a cross with cross pieces at the ends, “double potent” means two cross pieces at the ends; “sable” is black; “or” is gold; “charged” means superimposed upon; “chief” means on top of; “azure” is blue; “seme” means strewn or scattered. In the middle of the apron is a black key and around it a wreath of laurel. The laurel symbolizes the good opinion our brethren have for us.

The order is of white, watered ribbon edged with red, worn as a collar, from which the jewel is suspended.

The jewel is the Teutonic Cross shown on the apron.

There are also gloves and a scarf among the clothing of a Knight Commander of the Temple. The colors of these, as well as of the apron and order, are white, red and black. The last of these is symbolic of the death of one who will be revealed in a later degree.

DUTIES

Be devoted to truth, honor, loyalty, justice and humanity.

LESSONS

Masonry is practical and requires its members to be actively involved in life.
Virtue and duty have been the same in all times.

FOR REFLECTION

It is nobler to err and make amends than never to err at all. Is this statement contrary to the virtue of prudence?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The colors scarlet and black, garland of laurel, circles and globes, swords drawn and extended to a central point.

In many of the degrees of the Scottish Rite, the candidate is styled a knight; this, however, is the first of the truly Chivalric Degrees. The flourishing of knighthood during the Crusades of the Middle Ages, (1100–1400 A.D.) has been the subject of romantic legends, epic poems, books, theater, art and song for over 600 years. Perhaps the most well known of the chivalric legends is that of King Arthur and the Knights of the Round Table. King Arthur assembled around him the most virtuous and gallant men. He created them knights and thus devoted them to the causes of right, the poor and needy, and honor. His kingdom became a paradise on earth. This idyllic world came tumbling down when the frailty of the flesh prevailed—a knight fell in love with Arthur's queen and Arthur's step–brother greedily and jealously pursued the throne.

In reality, too, the age of knighthood came to an end as a result of human weaknesses—greed, political and religious corruption and, in general, the loss of

the selfless attitude held by knights and demanded by the rules of chivalry. Despite the fate of knighthood, the chivalric ideal has survived as one of the noblest conceptions of the human spirit and provides the support for the ideals of family unity, moral education, honor and courtesy, all of which Masonry teaches as its duties.

A formal process developed for the making of a knight; commonly three levels were recognized—valet or page, squire and finally, knight. Special ceremonies accompanied transition from each stage. Knighthood was always a Christian institution and in the ceremony certain parallels existed to the sacraments of Christian faith: the white clothing and bath bring to mind baptism, the stroke on the neck and embrace compare to confirmation. As gifts accompanied baptism, so too, the person conferring knighthood presented a gift or granted a favor to the newly created knight. Prior to actual investiture, the knight–to–be endured fasts and a night of prayer or vigil in the church.

Since knighthood originated with professional cavalry warriors, part of the ceremony included arming the newly made knight. A knight received spurs, coat of mail, the cuirass (protective chest armor), the gauntlets (gloves of mail), belt and sword. The sword was two–edged to remind the knight that he must maintain chivalry and justice. The coat of mail, gauntlets and cuirass were symbolic of the fortress erected against vice. The spurs served to urge the knight onto deeds of honor and virtue.

During the Crusades groups of knights often banded together for common purposes such as to protect the travelers to the Holy Land or to reclaim Palestine from the Moslems for the benefit of Christianity.

At the end of the Crusades in the Holy Land, the Teutonic Knights carried their crusade to Eastern Europe and conquered Prussia. This expanded their territory and influence. They were permitted by the Pope to engage directly in trading activities, despite their previous vows of poverty. The Order’s expansion and increasing power aroused the hostility of neighboring countries which joined forces to finally defeat the Order. In 1466 a treaty entitled the Order to maintain some lands in Prussia but its Grand Master became a vassal of the Polish king.

The complete dissolution of the Order began in 1525 when its Grand Master converted to Protestantism and its lands reverted to Poland. Remnants of the Order, with scattered land holdings, existed until 1809 when Napoleon finally divided the lands among other principalities.

CEREMONY

The Chapter of Commanders, the name of this body, is decorated with scarlet hangings, signifying fidelity and zeal, and black columns, a reminder of death. Both the hangings and columns are arranged so that the Chapter is in the shape of a circle. The candelabrum is made of three tiers, all in the shape of a circle. In the room is a large round table upon which are five lamps with globular shades arranged in a simple cross. A crucifix, symbolic of the martyrs of Masonry, and a garland of laurel, representative of victory over the passions, are on the table. A sword and key crossed, also on the table, is a symbol open to many interpretations; it may best be understood here as signifying the twin allegiance of the knights to both temporal and spiritual authority. The circles and globes of the decorations of the Chapter represent the brotherhood and equality of the Masonic fraternity and the future state which is attainable by the practice of the knightly virtues.

The candidate represents a Prince of Mercy but is still called Constans, as in the preceding degree. He seeks the title of Knight Commander of the Temple to signal his zeal for Masonry. Before admittance to the main room where the Chapter is in meeting, he must, within a small apartment lit by a single candle, symbolically prepare himself for the great honor to be bestowed upon him. To the ancients the breaking of bread and eating of salt at a meal were symbols of a pledge of faith and loyalty. Thus the candidate partakes of water, bread and salt to affirm a solemn pledge to answer and act truly and honorably. The candidate must provide in writing a confession of error to anyone whom he has wronged or injured, promising to make amends at the earliest opportunity. A second letter offering reconciliation to a brother of the Rite with whom a quarrel exists must be offered in order for the candidate to continue in the ceremony. The Chapter

seeks to determine whether the candidate is a true Mason and as such willing to atone for a wrong done anyone and not too proud to offer reconciliation to a brother.

With charity and humility, the candidate encounters the threat of death, a somber reminder of the fate of all men and a symbol of his resurrection in virtue. As the Teutonic Knights took vows of chastity, obedience and poverty, the candidate vows to never betray female innocence, comply with the reasonable commands of his superiors in Masonry and not neglect the obligations of charity within his means.

At this point in the drama, the Master of Ceremonies assumes the character Constans, who, seeking knighthood, must stand vigil at the altar until dawn. Under no condition is he to leave his vigil, for to do so will show him without honor and unworthy to become a Knight Commander of the Temple. During the long night, Constans faces many temptations. An officer bears a message from Constans' betrothed, pleading for him to join her at festivities held that night. An old rival for the hand of Constans' lady is at the feast pursuing her. If Constans does not join the festivities at once, his betrothed says she will not see him ever again because it is clear he does not love her. Constans, of course, refuses saying he will do her bidding in all that does not affect his honor.

Again temptation breaks the silence of the vigil. An enemy, knowing of Constans' vigil, has taken this opportunity to attack his castle. The battle is not going well and surely Constans will lose his entire estate if he does not join the fight. Constans chooses to maintain his vigil for worldly possessions are not enough to break the trust between himself and those who vouched for him.

A monk then disturbs the solemn watch, praising Constans' ability to withstand the temptations of worldly love and earthly possessions. He declares Constans worthy to become a monk and thereby assure his soul's salvation, for to live in the desert far from the deceptions of the world, devoted to penance and mortification of the flesh, is the surest way to salvation. Constans refuses the monk's arguments, trusting in a God of love who will recognize his honor and service to others as a noble path to salvation.

The sounds of battle intrude upon Constans. Rushing to the window, he sees the city under attack by brutal enemies without mercy or pity who will enslave his people. Constans declares he cannot put his own desires and ambitions before the lives and liberty of his fellow citizens; he rushes out to join the battle. Because Constans left his vigil, the tide of battle was turned, the enemy driven off and the city saved; but no one knew who this mysterious defender was, for he disappeared after the battle.

The Master notices Constans is not at his vigil. When Constans returns, the Master chastises him severely and declares him devoid of prudence, temperance and fortitude, thus unworthy of knighthood. Suddenly, a knight recognizes Constans as the unknown defender. The Master acknowledges his error, stating it is nobler to err and make amends than never to err at all. Although Constans left his vigil, he did so unselfishly for the cause of justice and humanity and will receive his desired title.

He is obligated a Knight Commander of the Temple, vowing obedience and fidelity to Masonry and its great truths, to his country, to his own principles and to the service of the poor, unfortunate and sick. He promises never to avoid danger when duty and manhood require him to remain, even though death is possible. The trophies of the degree are presented to him: the garland of laurel, meant to crown his good works, symbolic of the victory over the frailties of the flesh; the apron, gloves, collar and jewel of the Order in colors of red, white and black, symbolizing zeal, fidelity, purity of motives and sorrow for a martyr of Masonry who, for the moment, remains unnamed; the sword, emblematic of justice, truth and a Knight Commander’s duty to defend right from wrong; the spurs, symbolic of active force and the moral virtues of a Knight; and the red mantle embroidered with the Teutonic Cross, emblem of the Order, to remind him of his duty to God, the Masonic fraternity and the poor.

As a Knight Commander, the candidate is told the qualities of a knight are humility, temperance, chastity, generosity and honor, represented by the cross on the table. Of these qualities, honor is the life of a knight. To follow the path of honor is to follow the path of duty—duty to God, the Fraternity and humanity.

In closing, the Knights all draw their swords and extend them to a central point, signifying the common purpose of Masonry. They renew their vows to be of one mind, one heart and one soul, devoting their swords to the cause of freedom, their hearts to the glory of God, their intellects to the enlightenment of men and their hands to works of charity.

LECTURE

The lecture is brief and very direct. It teaches us that Masonry is practical and that we should be actively engaged in the duties of life. Although the days of knighthood are long passed, virtue, duty, truth and loyalty are needs of all ages.

Honor, Loyalty and Duty:

[The Mason] *is not only a Moralist and Philosopher, but a soldier, the Successor of those Knights of the Middle Ages, who, while they wore the Cross, also wielded the Sword, and were the Soldiers of Honor, Loyalty, and Duty* (p. 578).

Times change, and circumstances; but Virtue and Duty remain the same. The Evils to be warred against but take another shape, and are developed in a different form (p. 578).

There was a time when a Knight would die rather than utter a lie, or break his Knightly word. The Knight Commander of the Temple revives the old Knightly spirit; and devotes himself to the old Knightly worship of Truth. No profession of an opinion not his own, for expediency's sake or profit, or through fear of the world's disfavor; no slander of even an enemy; no coloring or perversion of the sayings or acts of other men; no insincere speech and argument for any purpose, or under any pretext, must soil his fair escutcheon. Out of the Chapter, as well as in it, he must speak the Truth, and all the Truth, no more and no less; or else speak not at all (p. 579).

To purity and innocence everywhere, the Knight Commander owes protection, as of old; against bold violence, or those, more guilty than murderers, who by art

and treachery seek to slay the soul; and against that want and destitution that drive too many to sell their honor and innocence for food (p. 579).

To the performance of duty and acts of heroism ... you have devoted yourself, my Brother, by becoming a Knight Commander of the Temple. Soldier of the Truth and of Loyalty! Protector of Purity and Innocence! Defier of Plague and Pestilence! Nurser of the Sick and Burier of the Dead! Knight, preferring Death to abandonment of the Post of Duty! Welcome to the bosom of this Order! (p. 580).